Zipper Algebras: Mathematical Context and Software Specification

27 October 2026

1 Mathematical purpose

Zipper algebras arise in the study of quotients of braid group algebras and representations motivated by quantum topology. Bigelow introduced them in [1, §8, pp. 297–298], asking whether the three-strand slider vanishes and which additional relations yield finite-dimensional quotients (Questions 6 and 7). The Hecke and BMW quotients provide familiar points of comparison. The research programme developed in [2] constructs a family of untwisting quotients and asks how their algebraic structure depends on the untwisting polynomials.

The zipper algorithm and its finite-generation consequence give the broader mathematical setting for this software. The computational questions include whether one slider or untwisting relation follows from others, how presentations change with the untwisting choice, and how to obtain explicit identities that prove those dependencies. The package supports these questions through exact noncommutative algebra, proof expansion, two-sided ideal certificates and rational-function reconstruction.

This reference first defines the algebras and states the relevant thesis result, then specifies the implemented presentations and verification requirements and conclusions. The geometric algorithm and its diagrams have their own exposition in [2, §3.4].

2 Ambient algebras and conventions

Put $P = \mathbb{Q}[q,t]$ and $K = \mathbb{Q}(q,t)$, where q, t are algebraically independent central indeterminates. For $n \geq 2$, use the free associative algebra

$$F_n = P\langle x_1, \ldots, x_{n-1}, y_1, \ldots, y_{n-1}\rangle.$$

A word is an ordered tuple of indices in that displayed generator order, starting at one. The empty tuple represents the unit. Concatenation denotes multiplication, in the order written. In the braid group algebra, x_j maps to σ_j and y_j to σ_j^{-1}. Over a commutative coefficient ring R, the corresponding braid group algebra is $R[B_n]$, with q a unit when using the untwisting hypotheses below.

The presentation explicitly includes the inverse relations $x_j y_j - 1$ and $y_j x_j - 1$, adjacent braid relations and far commutations, together with redundant inverse or mixed-sign versions used by the reduction engine. Let J_n be the ideal generated by the braid and inverse relations. Passing from F_n to F_n/J_n identifies freely different words representing the same braid. Consequently, an identity in the braid group algebra need not be a literal free-algebra identity. The maintained

verifier checks the latter. A certificate using braid simplification must supply the corresponding braid/inverse terms or use a separately specified group-algebra checker.

3 Sliders, zipper algebras and untwisting

The following conventions translate [2, Definitions 2.6, 2.9 and 3.1] into the generator notation used by the package. Specifying word order is essential: a product of inverse generators in ascending order is generally not the inverse of the ascending positive product.

3.1 Sliders

For a block of i strands starting at j, define

$$U^+_{i,j} = x_j x_{j+1} \cdots x_{j+i-2}, \qquad U^-_{i,j} = y_j y_{j+1} \cdots y_{j+i-2}.$$

The slider recursion is

$$\begin{aligned} S_{2,j} &= qy_j + (1-q) - x_j, \\ S_{i,j} &= (q^{i-1}U^-_{i,j} - U^+_{i,j})S_{i-1,j} \quad (3 \le i \le n), \end{aligned}$$

with $1 \le j \le n-i+1$. The unshifted slider X_i means $S_{i,1}$; the thesis writes the shifted slider as $X_{i,j}$. These are explicit elements of the braid group algebra, not additional generators. Bigelow's barred indexed word denotes the inverse of the entire indexed product. Translating that abbreviation gives the same recursion [1, p. 298].

3.2 The zipper algebra

The level-two zipper relator is

$$Z_{2,j} = (qy_{j+1} + 1 - q - x_{j+1} - qy_j y_{j+1} + x_j x_{j+1})S_{2,j}.$$

For $i \ge 3$, the emitted higher zipper relator is

$$Z_{i,j} = \big(q^{i-1}U^-_{i,j+1} - U^+_{i,j+1} - q^{i-1}y_j U^-_{i,j+1} + x_j U^+_{i,j+1}\big)S_{i,j}.$$

Here $3 \le i \le n-1$ and $1 \le j \le n-i$; for level two, $1 \le j \le n-2$. In particular, the two-strand formula is separate and includes its scalar term $(1-q)S_{2,j}$.

The zipper algebra is

$$\mathcal{Z}_n(R,q) = R[B_n]/\langle Z_{i,1} : 2 \le i \le n-1\rangle.$$

The displayed polynomials are read in $R[B_n]$ for this definition. The builder also emits their shifted versions. These generate the same ideal: conjugation by $\sigma_1 \cdots \sigma_{n-1}$ shifts each σ_k to σ_{k+1} while $k \le n-2$, so successive conjugations translate each supported block.

Imposing $X_2 = 0$ gives the Hecke quotient: indeed $\sigma_1 X_2 = -(\sigma_1 - 1)(\sigma_1 + q)$. For $n \ge 3$, the quotient of the zipper algebra by $X_3 = 0$ and $(\sigma_1 - t)X_2 = 0$ is the BMW braid-generator presentation described in [1, §8] and [2, §3.2]; see also [3, 4]. The parameter comparison with the conventional BMW generators is discussed below.

3.3 The family of polynomial untwisting quotients

For $i \geq 3$ set

$$\Theta_{i,j} = U^+_{i,j}(x_{j+i-2} \cdots x_j), \qquad \Theta_i = \Theta_{i,1}, \qquad \Theta_2 = x_1.$$

These are the lasso twists of the thesis; $\Theta_3 = x_1 x_2^2 x_1$. For monic polynomials $p_2, \ldots, p_n \in R[\lambda]$ with unit constant terms, form the two-sided quotient

$$\mathcal{Z}_n^{(p)} = \mathcal{Z}_n(R, q)/\langle p_2(x_1)X_2, p_3(\Theta_3)X_3, \ldots, p_n(\Theta_n)X_n\rangle.$$

This is the class of algebras in [2, Definition 2.9], allowing an independent untwisting polynomial at every level.

Finite-generation theorem (Moos). *With $q \in R^\times$ and the above monicity and unit-constant-term hypotheses, $\mathcal{Z}_n^{(p)}$ is finitely generated as an R-module. In particular, over a field it is finite-dimensional.*

This is the finite-generation formulation of [2, Theorem 3.41, p. 62]. The theorem follows from the zipper algorithm's layered-zipper spanning result (Theorem 3.39): there are finitely many combinatorial layer types up to twisting, and the polynomial relations bound the remaining twist exponents. Monicity reduces positive powers; a unit constant term also permits reduction of negative powers. Thus the theorem supplies a family to study as the polynomials vary. It does not assert that the resulting spanning set is a basis, determine the dimension, or establish semisimplicity.

3.4 Presentations implemented by the software

The function `build_relations_ring` is in `src/zipper_algebra/zipper_in_ms.py`; its front end is `Presentation` in `src/zipper_algebra/presentation.py`. A presentation records the strand count, untwisting choice, powers, level limits, imposed zero sliders and named additional relations. Its symbolic relation content is hashed; readable labels alone do not identify an algebra. The builder implements selected members and variants of the preceding family, rather than arbitrary polynomial input.

In the canonical untwisting presentation,

$$T_{2,j} = (x_j - t)S_{2,j}, \qquad T_{i,j} = \big(x_{j+i-2} \cdots x_j - q^{i-1} y_{j+i-2} \cdots y_j\big) S_{i,j} \quad (i \geq 3).$$

In the braid quotient, left multiplication by $U^+_{i,j}$ converts the second equation to $(\Theta_{i,j} - q^{i-1})S_{i,j} = 0$, where $\Theta_{i,j} = U^+_{i,j}(x_{j+i-2} \cdots x_j)$. This equivalence uses invertibility; the two expressions are different polynomials in the free algebra.

3.5 Experimental parameter choices

The builder also implements a level-two power relation $(x_j^a - t)S_{2,j}$, the squared relation $(x_j - t)^2 S_{2,j}$, and a historical option $(x_j^2 - t^2)S_{2,j}$. The twist-power parameter affects level three only: for exponent $m > 1$, the emitted relation is $(\Theta_{3,j}^m - q^{2m})S_{3,j}$. At higher levels the canonical relation remains. The software does not yet accept an arbitrary untwisting polynomial as input. No structural theorem about a variant follows simply from choosing a flag.

The public presentation object rejects unknown untwisting choices, noninteger strand counts and powers, level bounds outside $2, \ldots, n$, repeated additional relation labels and targets requiring more

strands than are present. Numeric coefficients use either $\mathbb{Q}$ or $\mathbb{Z}/m\mathbb{Z}$. Calling the latter a field requires the additional hypothesis that m is prime; the coefficient backend does not perform a primality proof. Nonunits cannot be inverted.

4 Certificate data and exact conclusion

Let $r_1, \dots, r_s \in F_n$ be the ordered defining relations of a specified presentation. A certificate for $f \in F_n$ is a finite list of terms $(u_\nu, i_\nu, v_\nu, N_\nu, e_\nu)$, together with an ordered family of nonzero polynomials $a_1, \dots, a_h \in \mathbb{Z}[q,t]$. Here u_ν, v_ν are words, i_ν names an actual relation, $N_\nu \in P$, and $e_\nu \in \mathbb{N}^h$. The intended identity is

$$f = \sum_\nu \frac{N_\nu}{D_\nu} u_\nu r_{i_\nu} v_\nu, \qquad D_\nu = \prod_{k=1}^{h} a_k^{e_{\nu k}}, \tag{1}$$

in $K\langle x_1, \dots, y_{n-1}\rangle$. Atom irreducibility is unnecessary for checking this identity; it is relevant to reconstruction efficiency. The atom search bounds do not limit the exponents in a composed certificate.

Define $E_k = \max_\nu e_{\nu k}$, with zero maxima for an empty certificate, and $M = \prod_k a_k^{E_k}$. Since P is an integral domain and each atom is nonzero, $M \neq 0$. The exact checker compares the polynomials

$$Mf \quad \text{and} \quad \sum_\nu N_\nu \left(\prod_k a_k^{E_k - e_{\nu k}} \right) u_\nu r_{i_\nu} v_\nu. \tag{2}$$

Equality proves (1) and hence membership of f in the two-sided ideal generated by the relations over K. It also proves membership in the corresponding localization of P, inverting the used atoms. A specialization of the rational identity is available wherever its displayed denominators are nonzero. The polynomial identity (2) remains meaningful at their zeros, but need not imply the specialized membership statement there.

The certificate boundary rejects zero atoms, nonintegral atom coefficients, negative or noninteger polynomial exponents, denominator vectors of the wrong length, inexact numerical coefficients, out-of-range word indices and unknown relation labels. Both verifiers validate the supplied presentation identity. Objects are revalidated at the checking boundary because their data are mutable. A malformed certificate raises a validation error. A well-formed false identity returns a report with `pass=False`.

Legacy files without a presentation hash require an explicitly supplied presentation. Their historical origin does not replace verification against those actual relations. New certificates should retain the presentation hash and explicit target. Named sliders, additional named targets and direct polynomial targets share the same validated target resolution.

5 Independent polynomial identity testing

The second checker evaluates the cleared identity on a product grid of distinct rational integers. For each parameter, its bound includes both the target degree plus the clearing-factor degree and the degrees of every cofactor term. If the bounds are (d_q, d_t), a grid with $(d_q + 1)(d_t + 1)$ points suffices.

Proposition 1. *If a polynomial in $\mathbb{Q}[q,t]$ of bidegree at most (d_q, d_t) vanishes on such a product grid, it is zero.*

Proof. Fix a grid value of t and apply the univariate root bound in q. Each coefficient in q then vanishes at all $d_t + 1$ values of t, so the same root bound makes each coefficient zero. Apply this to every free-word coefficient. □

The checker evaluates the polynomial product M/D_ν directly, rather than dividing its evaluations. Thus grid points at poles cause no undefined division. Negative numerator exponents are rejected: a Laurent polynomial cannot use this polynomial degree bound without additional clearing. This exact finite-grid argument differs from checking a few selected parameter values. Its arithmetic is separate from the symbolic accumulation, but it shares the presentation builder, input validation and target resolution.

6 Proof expansion and contextual composition

A basis proof is an acyclic directed graph expressing each basis element as a sum of contextual multiples of input relations and other basis elements. Forward references are allowed; cycles and missing dependencies are errors. Substitution respects multiplication order. If

$$g_k = \sum_\nu c_{k\nu} L_{k\nu} r_{i_{k\nu}} R_{k\nu}, \qquad f = \sum_s m_s u_s g_{k_s} v_s,$$

composition produces terms with coefficient $m_s c_{k_s\nu}$ and contexts

$$(u_s L_{k_s\nu},\ i_{k_s\nu},\ R_{k_s\nu} v_s).$$

No commutation or cancellation of free words is implicit. Repeated uses of one basis element remain separate until their full contexts agree and coefficients can be added. The number of multipliers must equal the number of skeleton steps, and an explicit nonzero skeleton remainder precludes membership composition.

For sampled multipliers, each sample reduction must have the same ordered sequence of (u_s, k_s, v_s) as the anchor, where k_s is the leading-word key rather than the engine's changing numerical index. The data retain one multiplier per occurrence. A sample with a different contextual schedule is excluded. A successful fit is a candidate; the resulting identity still needs exact verification.

7 Exact reconstruction of candidates

A sample consists of a distinct parameter point in $\mathbb{Q}^2$ and an exact rational value. Repeated locations count once; conflicting values and floating-point coefficients are rejected. For a fixed nonzero denominator proposal and a numerator bidegree bound, interpolation uses the available fitting rows and requires full column rank. A consistent rank-deficient system does not determine a unique numerator and is not completed by arbitrarily setting free variables to zero. Numerator coefficients belong to $\mathbb{Q}$, rather than necessarily $\mathbb{Z}$.

Univariate rational reconstruction fixes a monic denominator, solves the exact linear system, cancels a polynomial greatest common divisor and normalizes the result. The reduced denominator must be nonzero at every supplied point, and the candidate must match every fitting and held-out value.

This prevents a spurious cross-multiplied equation $0 = 0$ from concealing an incorrect sample at a pole.

Held-out locations are reserved before fitting and denominator inference. Their coefficients do not participate in inference of the factor family. A passing held-out check is additional evidence, not a rational-function identity proof. Line restrictions can cause distinct polynomial factors to coincide, so inferred exponents are heuristic proposals. They are validated and have a general-search fallback. For arbitrary declared factors, absence of a cancellable whole factor does not imply coprimality of the numerator and denominator; stronger assertions require irreducible, pairwise nonassociate factors.

Failed predictions, an unavailable common reduction shape and exhaustion of the chosen degree or factor bounds do not show that more data cannot help. The experimental driver retries within its sampling cap and reports an inconclusive outcome when it lacks an exact certificate. In particular, reducing to a nonzero remainder against an uncertified basis establishes no nonmembership conclusion, even at that specialization. The historical exception name `WrongClass` is retained as a subtype of `NeedMoreSamples`; it is an inconclusive diagnostic. Candidate reconstruction is characteristic zero.

8 Research results and computational evidence

The linear untwisting case connects the family above to the BMW quotient. The thesis exhibits an explicit two-sided identity for X_3 using the zipper, two-strand linear untwisting, and three-strand canonical untwisting relations [2, Theorem 4.1 and Appendix A]. Its denominator is $D = t^4(t+q^2)$; the stated conclusion applies where D is invertible. Corollary 4.2 identifies the resulting quotient with the BMW presentation under the parameter hypotheses of Proposition 3.15. For comparison with the conventional parameters, adjoin a chosen $q^{1/2}$ and assume $q, t, 1-q$ are units; then

$$m = q^{-1/2}(1-q), \qquad l = q^{1/2}t^{-1}, \qquad G_i \longmapsto q^{-1/2}\sigma_i, \quad E_i \longmapsto (1-q)^{-1}S_{2,i}.$$

This scalar extension is part of that parameter comparison.

The maintained historical free-algebra fixture and the thesis's compact braid-group-algebra representation use different ambient equalities. Checking the latter requires braid normal forms or explicit braid/inverse relation terms; it cannot be passed unchanged to the free-algebra checker. The large fixture is retained for reproducible regression checks.

The thesis also discusses dimension, module structure and possible semisimplicity patterns. These questions motivate experiments, but are separate from an individual certificate's conclusion. Neither an interpolation fit nor agreement at selected specializations supplies a generic identity. For the historical reconstruction, it is the final exact identity that supplies the membership proof; stability observed in finitely many sampled reduction shapes is evidence used in finding it.

A finite computation, a small residual or a successful process exit does not certify a completed generic Gröbner basis. Dimension and trace computations require basis-completion and exact-arithmetic evidence for their stated coefficient domain. Solver execution, generic basis certification and the experiment drivers retain separate completion requirements. The general finite-generation theorem gives mathematical context; the installed verifier checks the explicit algebraic identity submitted to it.

9 Verification commands and source map

The solver-free regressions and distribution checks cover strict certificate validation, noncommuting contexts, repeated basis occurrences, schedule alignment, poles, target degrees and historical certificate compatibility. See `docs/TESTING.md` for the maintained commands and optional integrations.

The maintained implementation is under `src/zipper_algebra/`:

- Presentation and relation formulas: `presentation.py`, `zipper_in_ms.py`.
- Certificate data: `cofactor/cofactor_io.py`, `cofactor/atoms.py`.
- Symbolic and grid checks: `cofactor/verify.py`.
- Proof graph and reduction: `cofactor/proof.py`, `cofactor/skeleton.py`.
- Symbolic composition: `cofactor/compose.py`.
- Coefficient reconstruction: `cofactor/lift.py`.

The experimental sampling driver is `tools/cofactor/pipeline.py`.

References

[1] Stephen Bigelow, *Braid groups and Iwahori–Hecke algebras*, in *Problems on Mapping Class Groups and Related Topics*, Proceedings of Symposia in Pure Mathematics **74**, AMS, 2006, pp. 285–299. In particular, §8, Questions 6–8. Author's copy; arXiv:math/0505064.

[2] Choomno Moos, *The Zipper Algebra*, M.A. thesis, University of California, Santa Barbara, September 2026. References here use the recovered manuscript with source SHA-256 beginning `c6ff7e634baf86ee`, and its accompanying PDF. Section and theorem numbers identify that version; the thesis is cited for its definitions and research results.

[3] Joan S. Birman and Hans Wenzl, *Braids, link polynomials and a new algebra*, Transactions of the American Mathematical Society **313** (1989), no. 1, pp. 249–273. doi:10.1090/S0002-9947-1989-0992598-X.

[4] Jun Murakami, *The Kauffman polynomial of links and representation theory*, Osaka Journal of Mathematics **24** (1987), no. 4, pp. 745–758.